12. China Under Alien Manchus: The Qing Dynasty

In the previous chapter, we looked at the status of Tibet and its long-standing relationship with the Mongol tribes. Even after the Mongol Yuan dynasty ruling China came to an end in 1368, Tibet remained under the influence of the surviving Mongol khanates. The Ming dynasty, which followed the Yuan dynasty, was an indigenous Han ruling house, but had no jurisdiction over Tibet. Neither did its jurisdiction extend to the Central Asian oasis towns which constituted the ancient Silk Road. It was under yet another conquering tribe from the north, this time the Manchus, that the territories ruled from Beijing reached their maximum extent. The Manchus established the Qing empire, which ruled China for over 250 years, from 1644 to 1912.

It is important to distinguish between a Chinese empire and the Mongol or the Manchu empire. As mentioned before, China was just one of the territories ruled by these alien ruling dynasties. The majority Han population resented the alien rulers and there were popular movements against them. These movements succeeded in overthrowing the Mongols in the fourteenth century, just as the republican movement unseated the Manchu Qing empire in 1911. However, whatever territory and non-Han people that were part of these foreign empires were subsequently claimed as historically being part of China. Thus, as we saw in the previous chapter, Tibet is claimed as having been part of China ‘since ancient times’. All the breaks in the political history of China have been neatly smoothed over and we are presented with a narrative of a continuous unbroken history of a civilizational China whose geography is eternal.

The Manchu Qing empire is important because the territories under its jurisdiction became the spatial foundation of the contemporary state of China. Thus, in addition to the Chinese heartland, occupied mainly by the